Methodology Report

1. Summary

The essay “Verification Relocates Trust: The Specification-Legibility Condition on Machine-Checked Proofs” was generated by a single AI model in a single pass, from a short task description. The human entrant did not supply any philosophical content (topic, thesis, argument, objections, examples or references) and did not edit the text.

2. Model and tools

- Model: Claude Sonnet 5.5 (model ID `claude-sonnet-5-5`), used through the Claude app, in a session with file tools.
- Tools used in the session: web page fetching (only to read the competition page, the detailed rules and the FAQ) and a file-writing tool to save the essay. No web search or retrieval was used to find or check philosophical literature.
- Memory: the account had memory enabled. The stored memory contains personal and coursework facts about the entrant and no philosophical ideas, so it did not supply content for the essay.
- No scaffolds, multi-agent setups, automated critics or automated scoring were used.

3. Process (in order)

1. The entrant sent the assistant the competition’s URL and the instruction to enter, with no topic, thesis or ideas.
2. The assistant read the competition page, the detailed rules and the FAQ, and confirmed that “primarily AI generated” essays with minimal human involvement are eligible.
3. The assistant chose the topic and thesis itself: the epistemology of machine-checked proofs, arguing that formal verification relocates trust from the proof to the statement (the “Specification-Legibility Condition”). The assistant chose it because it judged that the question allowed a precise argument within the word limit.
4. The assistant wrote the whole essay in one generation, including the argument, the distinctions, the two rival views, the objections and replies, and the worked contrast.
5. The assistant counted the words (about 3,150, below the 6,000 limit) and gave the entrant the essay and this report.

4. Human involvement

- Human actions: relaying the competition link and the instruction to participate; handling account registration, formatting into PDF and submission.
- Not done by the human: choosing or supplying a topic, thesis, premises, distinctions, objections, examples or citations; giving feedback on drafts; editing or rewriting any passage; selecting among candidate essays.
- Number of candidate essays or arguments generated: one. There was no selection, iteration or feedback round.
- Human time: limited to a few messages in one chat session (sending the instructions and preparing the submission). Financial cost: none beyond the entrant’s existing account.

5. Limitations and caveats

- The essay was not checked against the philosophical literature for originality.
- The four references (Burge 1998; Hardwig 1985; Thurston 1994; Tymoczko 1979) were cited from the model’s own knowledge. The assistant did not run a literature search to verify them.

- Because there was no iteration, the essay may contain weaknesses that a revision cycle with generic critique would have fixed.
- The chat log of the session is retained and available to the organisers on request.